

KNIGHTS' ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

During the early Middle Ages, the most common form of armour was a mail coat of riveted iron rings, which by the 13th century had turned into elaborate mail protection from head to toe. In the 14th century, solid metal was introduced into armour, beginning with small plates worn over vulnerable parts of the body, followed by more complete sets of plate during the 15th century: mail was retained only behind exposed joints in the armour. The most elaborate sets of armour were produced in the 16th century. By then, however, firearms were rendering extensive armour redundant.

► MAIL COIF

Date Medieval

Origin Europe

Material Iron

A mail coif – a close-fitting hood – was worn under the helm, leaving only the nose and eyes unprotected. Originally it was attached to the mail coat or hauberk, but was later separated. The example shown is a replica.



Mail flap was drawn across face for extra protection

▼ MAIL HAUBERK

Date 11th–12th century

Origin Northern Europe

Material Iron

The hauberk or byrnie – a knee-length shirt of mail such as the modern replica shown here – was the main item of armour in the 11th and 12th centuries. Knights wore a padded undergarment called an aketon underneath it.



Wide sleeves were originally bordered with plain bands

Slit allowed freedom of movement while on horseback

▼ MAIL AND PLATE ARMOUR

Date Late 14th century

Origin Italy

Material Iron and steel

By the mid-14th century, knights had begun to add plates of steel to their mail armour. At first a steel breastplate was added, then protective plates for vulnerable areas. This model demonstrates a transitional approach where mail was still retained for the lower torso, upper legs, chest, and upper arms.



Gilt latten border

Basinet with visor and aventail

Early breastplate of articulated plates, fitted with lance rest

Plate vambrace and couter to protect forearm, with short mail sleeve worn over the rerebrace

Sword belt with dagger worn low on the hips

Plate cuisse and poleyn to protect thigh and knee

Plate greave and sabaton to protect lower leg and foot